

KEVINFULLEDIT

Travel Radio Australia and November is the month of Remembrance Day on the 11th of November in Australia for our armed forces and I have a very interesting person, it's retired Brigadier Kevin O'Brien. He's also a prolific author and he's written a number of books including the Long Tan Book and you can find that online under longtanbook.com and Brigadier Kevin O'Brien, welcome to the program. Well thank you Geoff, it's nice to be here.

It's wonderful to talk to you. I wanted to, for our overseas visitors, just to explain your rank in the Australian Army because Brigadier is a very high rank. I was reading that it's the equivalent to a one-star General.

Can you tell us a bit about that? Yes, what happened at the end of the First World War, the British Army were directed to reduce the number of Generals. There was a rank called Brigadier General, then it was Major General, then Lieutenant General. So the Brigadier Generals, they just dropped the word General, so they kept the number of people but dropped the number of In France, it's a one-star General.

In America, it's one-star General. So it is in fact a one-star General from the point of view of rank. That's a very high rank and it's very impressive and thank you very much for your service with the Australian Army.

You were telling me in the research I was doing for this interview that there are a couple of misconceptions and things but you were actually there. Can you give us a bit of an overview of your experience? Well, the first thing is I was in Vietnam but I wasn't at this particular iconic battle of Long Tan. It occurred back in 1966 and at that time, I was still a cadet at the Royal Military College Duntroon but we were studying as part of our history studies the relationship between Vietnam and international relations with China.

When this battle occurred, it was a really iconic battle. It was the one where 18 Australians were killed in one day. In fact, in just a couple of hours and although the Australians had been in Vietnam for several years earlier, in the previous year, a whole battalion had lost 23 men killed but here we had on a single day with the new battalion, 18 killed and so it was a real shock not only because there were 18 killed in one day but of course, they were also national servicemen.

Up until then, there had only been regular soldiers and the government decided to introduce national service to bring in national servicemen. These were the first heavy hits on national servicemen. Yes, a very sad day for Australia back then and tell us your impressions of the Vietnam War in general.

You were explaining to me that as people say, it's a very fascinating time in history and I actually followed it, the withdrawal in 1975 which is an incredible situation when the Americans and the Australians left Vietnam. It's a very difficult situation particularly for servicemen because all of

those young soldiers that went to the war and of course, there were many, many more from the United States went to the war. In fact, I think it's 55,000 Americans were killed.

All of those young fellows went to the war, thought they were doing the right thing, did the best they could do. They showed courage under fire but in the end of course, the fall of Saigon, a lot of people would now say, well, what was it all for? Was it all wasted? What was it about? Indeed, that's the area that I've been researching to try and find out why it was that we went to the war. I've written some chapters on the Vietnamese history prior to Australia getting involved and America getting involved and then, you know, the reality is we did lose the war.

We left, we withdrew from Vietnam and we didn't withdraw. For example, you go back to World War I at Gallipoli, we withdrew from Gallipoli too but we went on to win the war. It's not the same in Vietnam.

There's always been this sort of stigma of, well, what was it all for? Did we waste our time? Was it all for nothing? Yes, there's a very contentious views going about this subject, isn't it? For and against and especially you as an army brigadier, you would have listened to opinions on this from everybody from the army, the politicians in Canberra and a lot of people have conflicting views on this. Certainly the case, Geoff. I mean, essentially what happened is, I'm talking about the Battle of Montaigne now.

The Australians decided that they wanted to have their own province. We had experience in Malaya and in Borneo. There was a belief in the Australian military that we could show the Americans how it's done and we could take our own province and we would manage things well and we would turn, you know, the people around.

In fact, that theory was actually very poorly thought through. The truth was we didn't really know what we were doing. The senior officers in the army didn't really know much about Vietnam.

In reality, they didn't know the history, the culture. They didn't understand how at the end of World War II, during which time Vietnam was occupied by the Japanese, the Japanese forces as they spread throughout Southeast Asia actually broke the European colonialism that had been around everywhere. It was the Philippines, Vietnam, Malaya, and what's now modern-day Indonesia, then the East Dutch East Indies.

So they threw out the Western powers, the Japanese that is. So a lot of people in those countries suddenly went, well, when the war's over, World War II's over, the war was fought for democracy, to beat fascism, surely we'll be allowed to be independent. We don't need to have a Western colonial power to run our country.

But of course, that was not the case in Vietnam. In Vietnam, the French who had lost a tremendous amount of prestige in World War II, where they'd been overrun very quickly by the Germans, the Vichy French had done a degree of cooperation and collaboration with their

occupiers. And indeed, in Vietnam, the Vichy French allowed, pretty much allowed the Japanese to take over.

Not unreasonably, the Vietnamese people didn't want the French to come back. And here is probably the monumental mistake in international relations here that we, the Western powers and particularly the United States, we didn't understand the wishes of the people and actually encourage them to have and support them for independence. And had we done that, there would never have been the war that we had because the Vietnamese people were fighting, at least initially, very much a war of independence to get rid of the French.

And they did that from 1945 through till around about 1949. They did it pretty much on their own. And the French only really survived because the Americans gave them weapons and support and air support and ammunition and money.

And then, of course, in 1949, when Mao overcame the nationalists in China, suddenly now the Vietnamese could turn to China for weapons and support. And so they got drawn into an international situation where the West didn't want communism. And so these poor peasants who really just wanted to get rid of the French suddenly were belonging and becoming to the Vietnamese, to the Chinese rather.

And so they got dragged into being an enemy of the West when probably the average little farmer and villager dressed with his rice paddy in his field, he didn't even know anything about communism or China, but he knew he wanted to get rid of the French. And indeed, eventually it became, once they defeated the French and the Americans arrived, it became an American war. So if it was really that period of time, we can't go back and change that now.

But I do think that in terms of international relations, we just didn't really understand what we were doing. Your book, thelongtanbook.com is available if people want to order it and have a read. At the moment, I'm just selling hard copies.

It's quite a serious book. It's got lots of really high quality photographs. It's in color, really good maps.

And what I've matched through is not just the stuff we've talked about, about how we got to the war, but this particular iconic battle. It's really quite interesting what happens in Australia. If you go back to 1900 with the Federation, we were relatively a country very much in people.

At the time of the First World War, there weren't very many people, four or five million. When Britain went to war with Germany, we just automatically went to war with Germany. There's sort of a feeling in Australia was we were a sort of white man in the other side of the world.

We needed a big brother, Britain. There was a sort of faith, if you like. If we help Britain in wars, in their activities, then Britain would come to our rescue and they would support us.

And that was the sort of attitude very much at the time of the First World War. So the first battle that Australia were ever involved in, which has become the Anzac Day, the biggest day of history for us, 25th of April, 1915, the Australian forces went ashore at Gallipoli. Now, in all truthfulness, most people in Australia wouldn't have even known where Turkey was.

The Australian generals had no say in where we landed or what we were there for or what it was all about. Even though we were now an independent country, the fact is we just did what Britain asked us to do and we went ashore at Gallipoli. And as you know, I mean, there were 8,000 Australians killed over the period of time in Gallipoli.

In terms of military results, there was no success whatsoever. I mean, those 8,000 people definitely died militarily for nothing. But the response to that in Australia was very much with letters coming from the king and information, it became one that had to be turned around.

It's where the spin doctors, if you like, take over. So the Anzac legend was created and it was created by a British journalist who saw none of the action. He was aboard ship when the landing occurred, but he was able to describe it in such a way that everyone in Australia was so proud of what our boys had done.

It became an epic victory, you know, the landing of Australians, rushing ashore under Turkish machine gun fire and storming the heights and so on and so forth. But of course, it just wasn't true. The Turks didn't have any machine guns when we landed.

It was such a kerfuffle that by the end of the first day, everyone wanted to leave, but they couldn't get them off. They fought on for eight months and it showed great perseverance. We all know how brave people were and what they did.

But what I'm saying is that we had this sort of idea that Australians were brave as lions and what we'd done was just a sort of an epic victory. Well, it just wasn't a victory at all. I mean, it's taken years, but nevertheless, Anzac Day caught on.

To this day, Anzac Day in Australia is a huge event pretty much based on a fallacy. It's one where, you know, whether it's a chip on a shoulder or what, I don't know. It's something that we just, you know, Australians like beating England in cricket and we want to say that Gallipoli, you know, we did the best.

You know, you could argue we did a good job, but the Turks did a better job in the end. We were defeated. I mean, that's the truth of it will matter.

If I turn that now to Long Can, at this Battle of Long Can, the Vietnamese forces decided to take on the Australians not long after we'd first arrived. So the brigade that took over the province, which is called Phuc Thuy province, a brigade of about 4,000 men, commanded by a brigadier, by the way, they arrived there in June of 66 and immediately set about building up a base and

defending the base in case it was the equivalent of what had happened to the French at Dien Bien Phu. So they did that rather successfully and the Vietnamese people obviously looked at them with some surprise and, you know, what are these fellas doing here? Who are they? One of the first things that the brigade commander did was there was a small village just outside the base area called Long Phuc.

He decided that that area was dangerous for him. People could mortar the Australians in the base from Long Phuc. And so what he did was he went through the Vietnamese authorities and he requested that all the people in that village be removed.

And indeed, basically at gunpoint, over a thousand Vietnamese villagers were tossed out of their houses. They got no compensation and they went into larger towns. And then the town itself, the village itself of Long Phuc, which was not, you know, a little building with little straw huts and things that you might imagine, it had tiled roofs, brick buildings, you know, timber, mahogany, centuries of occupation with family farms.

We bulldozed that village and burnt it. The result of that was that the local communists went, well, this is terrific. All those people are now on our side.

So we just failed to understand that this war was about the people. It wasn't about trees and soldiers and fighting. It was about the people.

So the outcome of that eventually is that within a month, the communist commanders in the area decided that they needed to teach the Australians a lesson. They decided quickly enough that to actually attack our base would be a disaster. We were obviously too strong, well-armed artillery, APCs, armoured personnel carriers, and we could draw on American air support.

Attacking us was not an option. So what they did instead was come down in the middle of the night on the 16th of August, night 16, 17 August, they brought down some mortars, some recoilless rifles, one artillery piece which had been captured from the Japanese, and they fired into the base and they wounded 23 Australians, one of whom was really quite seriously wounded. Why did they do that? They did it not to attack the base but to get us to come looking for the people that had attacked the base.

So it was basically a bait. Sure enough, the next day, we sent patrols out looking for them because they knew we were aggressive patrollers. A Bravo company of 6 RAR found the base plate positions, reported those back, and then the following afternoon, Delta Company, 6 RAR, who are the company that's involved in the battle, they relieved Bravo Company and they head off following the trails and tracks into the rubber plantation three or four kilometres away from the base.

Essentially, we have Vietnamese forces come down from the hills to teach Australians a lesson. They hit the base and they lure us out to what we network becomes, in fact, an ambush. Your

knowledge in this area, Kevin, is incredible.

I'm speaking with retired Brigadier Kevin O'Brien, who's the author of the long tan book dot com. You've researched this so thoroughly and you've, being a Brigadier in the Army, you have very much an inside view of all of this. It's a fantastic resource, this book, and it looks beautiful too.

I've seen a picture of it. It's absolutely gorgeous. If people want to order it from you, Kevin, how can they go about that? They go online? Okay.

You go online to the www.longtanbook.com and you can order it. You can buy it by PayPal or you can go directly to my account and direct debit the money. We'll post it out to you within two or three days.

I'm just negotiating with things like the War Memorial Bookshop at the moment and other bookshops, Collins Bookshops and others in Brisbane, but they're not available there at the moment. At the moment, you can only get it online. Over 400 copies have been sold already, which is a pretty good effort for a book that hasn't had any marketing other than this interview with yourself.

Look, Geoff, I'll just go back into the battle, if I can, for a moment to just point out what happened. Basically, they have lured us into an ambush and the mouth-to-tongue maxims and things, there's actually a term called lure the tiger from the cave. They lured us out of the base.

Essentially, what happens next is a very small contact occurs between a small number of the enemy and one of our platoons. They drop a particular modern weapon, which is called an AK-47. Everyone sees them today, a Kalashnikov Russian-type weapon.

You see it everywhere in the world today, but at that time, it was very new in the province. Indeed, the Australians had never seen one before. This very small contact with five or six guys, the reports which are in the signals logbooks that the five people they see are in uniform, they're wearing proper greens, military hats, carrying modern weapons, and no backpacks.

If you look at it in hindsight, it's pretty clear that it's some sort of a standing patrol, a sentry position. They drop one of these weapons, which is very unusual, and run directly east away. The platoon commander, who in fact is a National Sergeant, just a delightful young man, but he'd only been in the Army nine months, 12 months, he calls back to his more experienced major, who's back about 200 or 300 meters behind him, and he calls up on the radio and he says, this is what's happened.

Do you want me to follow up, and the major says, go for it. This phrase, go for it, is in many ways the theme of the book, because clearly the major who had served in Malaya, was an experienced regular soldier, didn't think it through. He didn't think that, I'm out here because they had all these heavy weapons.

Who has heavy weapons? Not local guerrillas, but main force units who could in fact even be from North Vietnam. What sentry position has modern weapons dressed in uniforms? Again, he should have thought through and said, whoa, these are main force regular troops, not local guerrillas. But anyway, he doesn't think of any of that, and he simply says, go for it.

And the platoon commander gets his 27 men, puts them out in extended line, which is one man next to the other, side by side, to sweep through the rubber plantation, and they walk, and they walk, and they walk. And about 700 meters later, a machine gun on the extreme left flank of them, which is on quite a prominent hill, which again, if you look at the map, it's pretty obvious, the machine gun opens fire, and within a couple of minutes, almost the entire left section, five men killed and two wounded, and they are absolutely pinned down, and they'd never seen a Vietnamese soldier. What we've actually had is an incredible ambush with catastrophic results.

Over the next couple of hours, eventually the platoon gets out of there, we come to that later on, they're saved only by the fact that the artillery is back in the Nui Dat base, is within range, they've got a radio set, they call in artillery fire, the artillery fire comes crashing down over their heads, over 3,000 rounds are fired, and eventually the best part of that platoon are saved, although it happens that there are 27 men there, 15 of them are left lying on the ground when they get away, so it really is a catastrophe. This is on a Thursday afternoon in Vietnam, the time difference is just three hours, by the time the news gets to Canberra, it's in the early evening of the Thursday night, suddenly the Prime Minister's office, you know, Gerald Holt is advised, goodness gracious, we've had a massive fight, and at that stage, they just knew that 15 men were missing, they didn't know if they were dead, alive, or captured, 15 had been left behind, and so you can imagine in Canberra, the panic that hit them, when up until then, there'd only been one national serviceman killed in the whole war, we'd never had a catastrophic battle like this, and so Canberra went into overdrive to turn what was in actual fact an ambush and a catastrophic disaster into a victory, not unlike what happened at the landing at Gallipoli, where, as I described earlier, we were able to turn it into this wonderful victory, when in fact, it really wasn't, and so that's really the tale of Long Tan. It doesn't mean that people weren't brave and courageous.

One of the fellows, the fellow who's a national serviceman, Lance Corporal John Robbins, with that left section, he's wounded, he's shot in the elbow, and he can't fire his rifle back, and falls to the ground. Later, when it's nearly dark, and the order is given to withdraw, and someone calls out, every man for himself, he gets up to run, he's still got his backpack on, but he can't carry his rifle, and he runs a few paces, and he's immediately, because they've announced their withdrawing, and jumped up, the local VC, who can see them, open fire again, and he's hit in the other arm, and he falls to the ground. One of the chap behind him, but closer to the enemy, sees him fall, he runs over to him, he says, help me with my pack, mate, and I can run.

He leans down, starts undoing his backpack, and he's immediately shot dead, and so John Robbins eventually does get home, and when I asked him about a month ago, when we were

doing the interviews for the book, a couple of months ago now, had he ever told anyone the story, and no, he said, essentially, I was a National Serviceman, I got evacuated back to hospital in Vung Tau, and then evacuated to Australia, my time was up, I got discharged, and no one ever asked me what happened. We have a case here of extreme courage and bravery, completely unrecognized, and yet these guys just absolutely did their best, but they were ambushed, and when you're ambushed, there's just no way you can ever recover when you're in the killing ground of an enemy force who prepared an ambush for you. These stories are part of Australian military history, and they deserve to be told, Kevin, and I suppose you're open too, if radio stations around Australia want to have a chat with you, they're very welcome to contact you via your website if they need to talk to you for things like Remembrance Day, Anzac Day, and all the military history for Australian military too.

Yes, Geoff, that's absolutely right. So the anniversary is, it's actually August next year, it's the 60th anniversary, and what's happened is it's become an iconic battle in Australia's sense, because it was the biggest number of casualties we ever took in a single day, and it's been adopted by Prime Minister Hawke, I think in 1988, adopted it as the Vietnam Veterans Memorial Day, and so that day, we've only got two days like this, we've got Anzac Day and Vietnam Veterans Day based on Long Tan, so it is a significant date. What I'd like to see, I suppose, in this whole thing is a degree of reconciliation with the Vietnamese.

If you go back to Gallipoli and the Turks, over the years there's been an admiration now between the two forces. Australians never talk about anything that Brave or we did this to the Turks or we beat them or we did that, they simply talk about the landing and the sacrifice and the commemorations, and we now see wonderful events every year at Gallipoli. We don't have that same situation in Vietnam up till date, but I'm hoping that this book will be, part of it is, I actually have a subheading for the book, I've called it Memories, Myths and Reality, and the reality is that we, after all these years, we're talking about 60 years ago, it's time for us to start mending the fences with Vietnam to actually saying, well, we know what you guys are doing, you were fighting for your own country, we were doing what we thought was the right thing, we were told to go there, it seemed like it was a good idea.

But in reality, the young soldiers on either side were both conscripts, both thought they had conscripts, we had conscripts. I think it's about time that we sort of commemorated things with healing and respectful commemorations to both sides. There's certainly large Vietnamese communities in Sydney, Melbourne and Brisbane, especially in Melbourne, in Richmond, where it's become very much an integral part of the city, and a lot of people came to Australia post-75 to settle in Australia, and connection between Australia and Vietnam now is absolutely fantastic.

Yeah, and of course, Vietnam has just absolutely prospered. I mean, all those sort of fear-mongering that was going around in the 60s about communism taking over and a place would fail and it'd be horrible and what have you, well, the worst fears weren't realised, I don't think. Vietnam today, now I haven't been back myself, but people tell me it's a wonderful place to visit,

the people are so prosperous and hard-working, as I say, it's time for us.

And of course, you'd argue that they're allies with us now. Everyone seems to be frightened of China. The Vietnamese are frightened of China too.

China occupied Vietnam for over a thousand years. So in 1979, China actually invaded Vietnam again and the Vietnamese fought them off. So there's very good reasons for, you know, both strategically, but also I just think from the point of view of soldiers, it's about time we shook hands and became friends.

Yes, exactly. And Kevin, it's been wonderful to have you on the program. As I say, people can get to your book online, thelongtanbook.com. It's in hard copy and it's selling all over Australia and internationally and Brigadier Kevin O'Brien is very happy to send you the book wherever you are.

It's a tremendous achievement and thank you so much for being on the program with us, Kevin. Well, thank you, Jeff. Great opportunity to try and get that message out.

Message of reconciliation and respect, I think, is the secret to the whole thing. It's not about one or who lost, it's about respectful commemoration. Thank you, Brigadier Kevin O'Brien.

Thanks very much for being on the program. Thanks, Jeff.